

7.1 Online Social and Business Networking Communities

By Ina O'Murchu, John G. Breslin, Stefan Decker

Introduction

In recent years, the Internet and especially the Web has enabled a communication revolution: the ability to send and retrieve information everywhere has changed the way we work and live. Internet based access to information and internet communication means have become ubiquitous. Web portals, as content aggregators, provide efficient access to information and services online: they are electronic gateways or entrances that provide numerous links to other sites and information that is needed. They provide a central concentrated focal point and an information source that can be personalized. They also allow people to gather detailed information and data as they need it and simplify access to information. They are playing increasingly important roles amongst online communities as audiences seek out more specific information, providing valuable opportunities for both profit and non-profit communities by helping to eliminate time consuming tasks such as administrative tasks and information dissemination. Social networking portals are a recent trend. A social networking site (SNS) connects and presents people based on information gathered about them, as stored in their user profiles. These user profiles determine the way in which users are able to present themselves to others. The most important distinguishing factor between the various sites is the range of profile information that they store and can perform operations on.

This paper will present a review of the various classifications of social networking portals: whether they are registration or connection based; whether user profiles are social or professionally oriented and if explicit relationships can be defined; whether sites are non-profit or profit-based. An evaluation will be carried out under the headings of searching capabilities; communication and collaboration features; perception of users; privacy measures; and